Buddhists centred around a monument that would be the precursor to the Great Stupa. It has been suggested, on slim evidence, that the settlement was at some point named Vijayapuri (‘city of victory’) to honour Vijaya Satkarni, a Satavahana king.[20]

In the early third century, this semi-urban settlement was ruled by Chamtamula, a feudatory of the Satavahanas. When the Satavahana Empire fell apart, around 220 CE, Chamtamula broke away and set up his own independent kingdom, founding the Ikshvaku Dynasty. Choosing the name ‘Ikshvaku’, he deftly linked himself to the prestigious *suryavanshi* (or solar dynasty) of Ayodhya’s Rama, establishing their divine justification to rule —most likely aided by collaborating priests.

Headstrong and ambitious, Chamtamula was a devotee of Karttikeya, the god of war. It’s possible that he himself renamed his new capital Vijayapuri. Though still only a chieftain, he performed the *Ashvamedha yagna*, a ritual horse sacrifice undertaken by major northern kings of the Vedic–Brahminical fold. His was perhaps the earliest instance of this ceremony enacted this far south, indicating that a lot of cultural diffusion had already happened, at least among the urban elites. This wasn’t the case in c. 500 BCE when the text of *Aitareya Brahmana* described the Andhras as a non-Aryan tribe that lived south-east of the Vindhyas, beyond the northern lands ruled by Brahminical elites. Chamtamula began building the citadel, issued his own currency (showing an elephant with raised trunk) and set about expanding his realm.

Their dates aren’t entirely certain, but a commonly accepted chronology of the Ikshvaku Dynasty runs a hundred years, from c. 220–320 CE, split more or less evenly between four kings: Chamtamula (c. 220–45 CE), Virapurushadutta (c. 245–70 CE), Ehuvala Chamtamula (c. 270–300 CE) and Rudrapurushadutta (c. 300–10/20 CE). Most inscriptions and the biggest Buddhist monuments date from the time of the second ruler, and most Brahminical monuments date from the time of the third. An inscription calls the third ruler *Dharma Vijayin*, and notes his aspiration to endear himself to all in the manner of Rama of Ayodhya. He bolstered Brahminism though it still likely remained a minority religion in the Ikshvaku realm. The Ikshvakus also struck alliances with other kingdoms by transferring their women to each other through marriage, as was the custom of the emerging